

This story was a special favorite of Dr. Russell Conwell, who founded Philadelphia's Temple University in 1884. The story inspired his classic lecture, "Acres of Diamonds," which he delivered more than 6,000 times, all the world over. The moral of the story: "Your diamonds are not in far distant mountains or in yonder seas; they are in your own backyard, if you but dig for them."

The very first student at what would become Temple was so inspired by the speech that he came to Dr. Conwell, eager for an education but unable to pay for one. Accepted on the spot for tutelage, the man went on to rise to a position of eminence and public service. I have no trouble believing that story because when, as a young man, I first read Dr. Conwell's lecture, its message also inspired me, even as it continues to inspire me today. And all of those fortunate discoveries of one diamond after another took place right in my own backyard, in a city in which I'd never before set my foot.

Coming to Philadelphia

It was just before Thanksgiving of 1945, shortly after the end of World War II, when this young resident of New Jersey first arrived in Philadelphia. My late twin brother, David, bless his soul, was with me; we were two 16-year-old boys getting off a bus from Blair Academy, coming to the City of Brotherly Love for the first time to celebrate the holiday with our mother and father. Our parents (my older brother, William, then 18, was serving in the U.S. Marine Corps) had recently moved into two rooms on the third floor of a modest home in suburban Ardmore, but the tiny space was enough for all of us—at least for the holidays. We ate our dinners at the small Horn & Hardart's restaurant around the corner. Later, when I was on vacation, I worked the graveyard shift at the Ardmore Post Office.